

**Request for a Renewal of a Grant to Cabrini Connections:
Knowledge Creation, Management and Application for Tutor/Mentor Organizations**

Last year's Fry Foundation grant to Cabrini Connections launched a long awaited project: the creation of a web-based system that could help document and analyze both prior and ongoing work of the Tutor/Mentor Connection (T/MC). The T/MC is one of two programs of Cabrini Connections, a small non-profit. The second program is a direct-service tutor/mentor program serving Cabrini-Green teens. The T/MC works to enhance conditions that support all tutor/mentor organizations in Chicago, including its own Kids' Connection. This web-based system, OHATS (Organizational History and Accomplishments Tracking System), was launched in September 2000. More than 200 T/MC actions were documented from September through March 2001 as T/MC staff and volunteers began to learn to document their actions on the Internet. Lessons and results from this project can be found in the Narrative and Financial Reports and the Six Month Summary OHATS Report presented to the foundation in May 2001 as well as on a website created specifically for this project: www.tutormentorexchange.net. OHATS continues to be used by T/MC staff and volunteers to document its actions and is now being prepared for use by other support organizations and programs. To date, five organizations have requested to use OHATS once the system is fully developed.

OHATS is designed to help program staff, volunteers and other stakeholders document how their organization or community initiative is acting to advance its goals and objectives. OHATS data collection methods are designed to help people document events, actions and accomplishments in a systematic manner so that records are more accurate and can be understood by more people inside and outside of the organization. The way items are documented in OHATS allows qualitative information to be categorized and analyzed in order to understand an organization's progress towards its goals. A fuller explanation and presentation of how OHATS works is at www.tutormentorexchange.net/Intro_OHATS.htm.

T/MC specifically designed OHATS as a web-based system to give all various stakeholders the ability to document actions related to T/MC without time, location and software-related restrictions. As a result, T/MC has been able to document the actions of multiple stakeholders, and more importantly, share these with more members (internal and external) of the organization. Instead of having actions collected in journals and calendars that are seen by few people and are difficult to organize and tabulate, each action recorded in OHATS is part of a growing database of information collected from many recorders and can be sorted and graphed to show the cumulative impact of T/MC. T/MC recorders documented more than 200 actions over a six-month period (a high amount compared to other applications of the documentation system that OHATS is based on). The preliminary report demonstrates how researchers, T/MC staff and stakeholders can see the influence the T/MC is having on Chicago's tutor/mentor community and on community organizers in other cities.

A renewal grant for this work will enable T/MC to:

1. Enhance the usability of OHATS data collection, reporting and analysis web tools.
2. Build a single, comprehensive database to organize and evaluate data collected from all T/MC events and research (such as data collected from annual surveys of needs and service of tutor/mentor organizations in Chicago and data from the annual city-wide Volunteer Recruitment Campaign).
3. Support (at least partially) a paid research member to manage and implement OHATS activities, including a retrospective documentation of T/MC actions since 1993.

T/MC will work with Steve Roussos, the researcher that helped develop OHATS, and with Chicago technology businesses to implement these enhancements.

Intended Outcomes

These enhancements are meant to expand what OHATS can be used for and its ease of use. As a consequence, a cascade of related short-term and long-term outcomes will be produced. This series of outcomes described here are part of a broader vision of what the T/MC imagines will exist as a result of this work.

The most immediate outcome will be that more organizations will understand how one small non-profit can have such a large unifying and resource building impact on hundreds of similar purpose agencies in a city as large as Chicago. This will result in more support for T/MC actions in Chicago as well as duplication of T/MC actions in other cities. This influence and interaction with other cities is critical for two longer-term outcomes. First, sharing of ideas across programs in other cities will help produce a national library of best practices. Second, as multiple

cities across the country adopt the T/MC approach for enhancing the tutor/mentor infrastructure, national funding strategies can be changed to support on-going operations of hundreds of tutor/mentor programs in and outside of Chicago.

As more organizations see how T/MC uses OHATS to show and improve its actions and impact, there will be an increased interest in and use of OHATS by others. Even within less than a year of early development, OHATS has attracted the attention of other tutor/mentor programs, support organizations and technology companies interested in the nonprofit market. As the number of organizations that learn to systematically document and evaluate their history of lessons and accomplishments increases, knowledge creation and sharing will increase. Eventually, the practice of knowledge creation and exchange will become a habit throughout the entire ecosystem of the tutor/mentor community, connecting CBOs, business partners, volunteers, faith groups, researchers, foundations, youth, families and educators in one learning and action network intended to help inner-city youth move through school and into careers. Eventually, other community networks (such as volunteer-based effort in health care or for elder care) will also adopt the OHATS system.

How long it will take to reach these different levels of impact is not clear. But, T/MC's experience with the growing attendance of its semi-annual peer-led training conferences, as well as the more widely known case studies of the growth of Linux "open source" software operating system, and even the spread of the Internet, all indicate that knowledge innovations that directly enhance a person's or organization's interaction with others will diffuse and grow exponentially. At this time, the ways that most nonprofit organizations learn how to improve themselves and share their lessons with others are not ways that lead to widespread diffusion and adoption. A Fry renewal grant would support three specific enhancements to the web-based OHATS that were strategically selected to help catalyze such a cascade of outcomes.

Why These Specific Enhancements Were Selected for a Renewal Grant

Our development of OHATS during the past year was specifically aimed to design a web-based system for program evaluation. The preliminary report of actions documented from September 2000 to March 2001 demonstrates the potential of this system. However, three important lessons were found during this development period. First, it is a challenge to discipline staff and volunteers in any organization to consistently document their actions. It requires even greater discipline to teach stakeholders to use the Internet as a place to document on-going activities. Second, because OHATS data and data collection methods were not directly tied with data and methods for program management and implementation (such as contact databases or program attendance), staff had to re-enter similar information and could not easily draw lessons from OHATS results to improve their daily work. Third, results documented from September 2000 to March 2001 only represent six-months of T/MC's accomplishments. *Influencing community change is a long-term process. To understand the value of OHATS and the impact of the T/MC, the organization needs to look at a longer period of time, and ideally, to identify historical events and accomplishments that were important for its growth and development.*

The three enhancements (making the OHATS web tools easier to use for more novice Internet users, connecting OHATS with other T/MC data sources and activities, and having a staff member to manage OHATS) will expand the number of T/MC stakeholders who document their actions regularly using OHATS. As a volunteer-based organization, the T/MC employs a small part-time paid staff that supports the collaborative actions of volunteers representing more than 100 other Chicago tutor/mentor programs. These volunteers participate in and help to organize the annual city-wide Recruitment Campaign and semi-annual T/MC conferences. In addition, volunteers from organizations such as Public Communications, Inc., the Chicago Bar Foundation, Jordan-Webb, and Amphion Productions help the T/MC mobilize public attention and resources for all of Chicago's tutor/mentor programs. Besides making OHATS easier to use through technological changes, the addition of a staff member to manage and guide OHATS activities would support training that encourages more of these stakeholders to use OHATS, and to learn from its documented results.

Community change in a city as large as Chicago involves hundreds of stakeholders and thousands of actions. The integration of the various T/MC databases and data collection methods that involve these stakeholders will enhance the ability of OHATS to demonstrate the comprehensive and integrated actions that are needed to increase resources available to support an entire city of tutor/mentor programs. As more people use OHATS to document actions related to the shared T/MC mission, we increase the likelihood that they interact with and begin to use OHATS on their own. Currently T/MC collects contact records on six unconnected databases. These are 1) T/MC web site

guest book; 2) the T/MC survey and Program Profile data (used to produce an annual directory of tutor/mentor programs in Chicago); 3) the T/MC daily contact log (calls from parents, DCFS, volunteers who are looking for programs); 4) T/MC master mail list and library of stakeholders (with over 13,000 records); 5) current OHATS database (records entered directly at OHATS web site); and 6) T/MC survey hosted at <http://jordan-webb.net/tmc>. By creating a data collection tool that captures data entered from any of these sources, OHATS is able to demonstrate a much richer range of interactions and influences than what is directly entered by current recorders. We create a single entry and long-term history for each contact that better demonstrates the long-term influence T/MC has on individual and group actions.

A more comprehensive knowledge creation and management system will enable users to see contributions and lessons from multiple stakeholders and from multiple activities. Further, integrated T/MC data sources (such as the T/MC conference database of participants and trainers since 1993) will allow users to identify relationships between activities and critical organizational events in OHATS with results from other citywide actions and programs. For example, we could identify the relationship between the number of media-specific changes documented in OHATS and change in program participation rates and new volunteer recruitment rates from the citywide T/MC recruitment campaign. These and similar analyses will enable T/MC and other organizations to implement more strategic and effective actions.

Finally, the addition of a staff member dedicated to the management of OHATS and the integration of T/MC database infrastructure will provide manpower for this work and help start the retrospective documentation of T/MC actions. The current OHATS results demonstrate work documented from September 2000 to March 2001. These results do not demonstrate the actions since 1993 that have led to the growth of T/MC and the development of its unique strategies to support tutor/mentor programs. It is impossible to assess the impact of T/MC based on such a short window of current results. While it will take 8 years to learn what T/MC accomplishes by 2008, T/MC seeks to conduct a retrospective study, documenting its actions since 1993. This study would be completed and published over the next year, providing an analysis of nine years of action and impact for the Chicago tutor/mentor community. At the same time, such a longer study would better demonstrate the value of OHATS for other support organizations that have a longer history of activity in Chicago. The standard measurement procedures built into OHATS are useable for such a retrospective evaluation, however this requires significant time and a dedicated staff person. Our initial progress with OHATS did attract the attention of students from the University of Chicago and the University of Illinois, however we without funding these interns were not able to work with us. We now seek the funding to hiring a full year intern to support the OHATS project.

One year of support from the Fry Foundation has resulted in rapid and exciting development of the OHATS web system. The summary report of OHATS results that was prepared for the Fry Foundation is also being sent to organizations such as GATX, iS3C, Fourth Bridge, IBM, Verizon, and numerous other foundations as part of requests for financial support of the T/MC. The demonstration of T/MC impact and method for critical reflection should produce more successful fund-raising necessary to sustain and expand the T/MC. This demonstration should also lead to the ability of the T/MC to market some of its services to other organizations and communities as a means of opening new channels of revenue that are not dependent on foundation or public funding.

A Fry Foundation renewal grant will enable specific OHATS enhancements and its potential far-reaching outcomes for the tutor/mentor community. The results of this project will help T/MC stakeholders be more united in the mission and actions of the organization, and more tutor/mentor programs and leaders from businesses, faith groups, and hospitals will understand and participate in the T/MC network, documenting their actions and contributions. The tracking functions of OHATS will help us to understand and improve such continued network building. As we build OHATS products and services, we will always take the greatest possible actions to openly display and share our products and our methods for creating them so that our peers can critique, adapt and continuously evolve the capacity to contribute to this common work. As organizations in Chicago and beyond learn the benefits of using OHATS as a tool to document and analyze their work, the system will become part of the actions of many other groups who are working to help youth move from poverty to careers.

Timeline

Project Activity or Task	Timeline
Finalize negotiations with Chicago technology partners for this project. **	September to October 2001
Work with Chicago technology partners to adapt OHATS data collection and reporting tools.	October to December 2001
Pilot test enhancements with staff from T/MC, Kids' Connection, and organizations that asked to participate in OHATS during this past year.	November 2001 to January 2002
Revise OHATS based on pilot test results.	January to March 2002
Raise awareness of OHATS by presentation and hands-on workshops for OHATS tools at the May 2001 Tutor/Mentor Conference.	2 days in May 2001
Publicize OHATS tools and results in T/MC newsletters, publicity events, and website.	Ongoing
Recruit and train staff member to conduct retrospective evaluation of T/MC using OHATS.	September to October 2001
Conduct retrospective documentation of T/MC's 1993 to 2002 history and accomplishments.	October 2001 to May 2002
Publish reports and overall summary of retrospective and prospective OHATS results of T/MC.	May to July 2002
Present methods and results of OHATS in at least two conferences related to nonprofit and/or evaluation issues.	January through August 2002

Budget (One Year Costs)

Item	Cost										
Salaries											
- Periodic technology and research support (approx. 200 hrs) **	\$15,000										
- Full-time staff for retrospective evaluation	\$25,000										
Supplies (materials, software, communication costs)	\$4,000										
Travel											
- 2 3-day trips from California to O'Hare) airfare, lodging, meals and transportation)	<table> <tr> <td>Airfare</td><td>\$1,000</td></tr> <tr> <td>Lodging</td><td>800</td></tr> <tr> <td>Meals</td><td>300</td></tr> <tr> <td>Transportation</td><td>100</td></tr> <tr> <td></td><td>\$2,200</td></tr> </table>	Airfare	\$1,000	Lodging	800	Meals	300	Transportation	100		\$2,200
Airfare	\$1,000										
Lodging	800										
Meals	300										
Transportation	100										
	\$2,200										
	TOTAL: \$46,200										

** Currently, discussions are taking place with technology businesses in Chicago to negotiate pro-bono and reduced costs for time and materials needed for this project.

Appendices

Final Narrative and Financial Report for this first year of this project submitted to the Fry Foundation in May 2001.